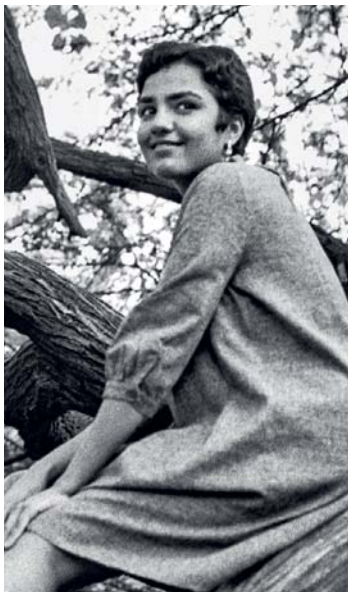
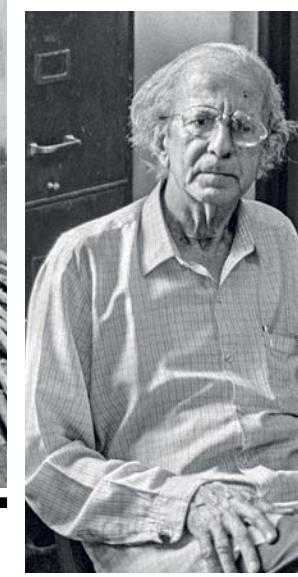








what 'Indian poetry' is.

Thayil says in the foreword that the book builds on *60 Indian Poets*, which he edited for Penguin back in 2008. In the new iteration, however, form is no longer the organising principle. The world had changed drastically, Thayil writes, and "democracy and reality were under attack". The anthology then necessarily captures a palpable conversation between catastrophe and hope.

The first poet in the book, almost obviously, is Nissim Ezekiel, widely considered the father of modern Indian poetry in English. His poems clearly reveal a period of discovery and wrestling. On the one hand, their lines bear the scaffoldings of British poetic meter but, on the other, are punctured by the muckiness of Bombay's daily grind.

However, even though Ezekiel marks the beginning, he comes to be a provisional origin. The arrangement of poets after him is not chronological. Instead, it is based on aesthetic impressions that come alive only in the process of reading these poets in tandem. (But for those readers who might find a historical lesson useful, halfway through, there is an essay by Bruce King on the Bombay group and their contemporaries. Also, the 'Afterword'—with some bitterness—confronts the unceasing criticism that English writing is 'not at par' with writing in other Indian languages.)

As we meander through the words of established poets and ones who have yet to publish their own collections, we begin to recognise, as Thayil says, "how vast, how riverine is the poetry". In the absence of the usual hierarchies of age, urbanity and fame, we also see a fractured poetic evolution. Given that most Indians' first encounter with English poetry continues to be through Tennyson, Eliot and Pound, this uncertainty makes perfect sense. For many of us, Ezekiel, Dom Moraes and Adil Jussawala come later, through a process of unlearning. True to these contradictions,



THE PENGUIN BOOK OF INDIAN POETS
Edited by Jeet Thayil
INDIA HAMISH HAMILTON
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THIS ANTHOLOGY DEMONSTRATES THAT LIKE INDIA, INDIAN POETRY IN ENGLISH, TOO, HAS NO SINGLE HERITAGE

this anthology embraces the belief that like India, Indian poetry in English, too, has no single heritage.

Despite the expanses between many of the poets, however, certain concerns persist—meditations on landscape, negotiations of 'mixed' identity, the pleasure and potential of language. Eunice D'Souza, for instance, pushes hard against the typical subjects of poetry, but also against their self-important ways of speaking. She begins 'Compound Life' with pithy observation:

The first-floor procuress/ takes the air.// Her bosom precedes her.

And yet, insight comes swiftly and with a wry sense of humour:

A bird hovers.// A word hovers.// A word is a bird/ Is a bird is a bird.

But there are other poets, like Tishani Doshi, who uphold ornamentation:

Lean backwards and listen to the slippery/ bastard of your own arrhythmic heart.// Remind yourself that you feel pain,/ therefore you must be alive.

Such contrasts between poetic voices propel the anthology, often taking it far away from any kind of literary preciousness. Where Ezekiel breezily mentions "*One day Ram Rajya is surely coming*", the pseudonymous poet Hamraaz—with poems like 'PM